

CASE ID: 202103710200

EPISODE NAME: China Retaliates Following Xinjiang Sanctions (UK)

2021/03/26 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: United Kingdom (200)

Issue: Retaliation (16)

Final Outcome: Ongoing

Summary:

On 2021/03/26, China imposed travel bans, asset freezes, and business activity restrictions on nine British citizens and four entities after the United Kingdom imposed sanctions related to human rights abuses in Xinjiang on 2021/03/22. Although six of the sanctions have been lifted, the episode remains ongoing.

Narrative:

After the United Kingdom sanctioned four Xinjiang senior officials, the Xinjiang Public Security Bureau of Xinjiang, and Xinjiang Production and Construction Corps in coordination with the European Union, United States, and Canada on 2021/03/22, China responded quickly.¹ On 2021/03/26, China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs announced that nine British individuals and four entities would face travel bans, asset freezes, and business activity restrictions.² The sanctioned individuals included five legislators involved in Inter-Parliamentary Alliance on China, two legislators leading the China Research Group, a Lawyer chairing the British Uyghur Tribunal, and an academic.³ The sanctioned entities included the China Research Group, Conservative Party Human Rights Commission, Uyghur Tribunal, and Essex Court Chambers.⁴

Sanctions on six of the nine individuals were lifted as part of an attempt to shore-up relations between the UK and China on 2026/01/30.⁵ The effected individuals stated that they had not agreed to stop criticizing China.⁶ The episode is ongoing.

¹ "UK sanctions perpetrators of gross human rights violations in Xinjiang, alongside EU, Canada and US." *Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office*, 22 March 2021. <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/uk-sanctions-perpetrators-of-gross-human-rights-violations-in-xinjiang-alongside-eu-canada-and-us>

² "Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Announces Sanctions on Relevant UK Individuals and Entities." *Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China*, 26 March 2021. https://mv.china-embassy.gov.cn/eng/fyrth/202103/t20210326_8915640.htm

³ "Uighurs: China bans UK MPs after abuse sanctions." *BBC*, 26 March 2021. <https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-56532569>

⁴ "Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Announces Sanctions on Relevant UK Individuals and Entities." *Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China*, 26 March 2021. https://mv.china-embassy.gov.cn/eng/fyrth/202103/t20210326_8915640.htm

⁵ Crerar, Pippa. "China has lifted sanctions from six serving British MPs and peers, Starmer says." *The Guardian*, 30 Jan. 2026. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2026/jan/30/china-lifts-sanctions-british-mps-peers>

⁶ Ibid.